

Review

Reviewed Work(s): The Durrell-Miller Letters, 1935-80 by Henry Miller, Lawrence Durrell and Ian S. MacNiven

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this work consists in the amount of detailed information it presents. Brecht's search for rationalism in music is the guiding thought structuring a book that is otherwise dominated by factual accounts. In his final pages Gilbert situates Brecht also in a broader historical context: looking into the past, he draws an interesting parallel between Brechtian "Gestus" and the eighteenth-century, preromantic concept of "Affektenlehre," and, considering the future, he wonders why Brecht's musical aesthetic has not had a wider influence on modern composers. All in all, with the unfortunate exception of unnecessarily frequent printing errors (probably the result of rapidly reworking a dissertation into a book), Gilbert's book is a highly useful contribution to Brecht scholarship, and readers of Brecht will grasp this only seemingly laconic statement as a meaningful compliment: "Es ist brauchbar."

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□ *The Durrell–Miller Letters, 1935–80*. Edited by Ian S. MacNiven. New York: New Directions, 1988. 528 pp. \$26.95.

The photograph on the dust jacket of *The Durrell–Miller Letters, 1935–80* displays a naked Henry Miller and Lawrence Durrell sunning themselves on a sandy beach, presumably somewhere in Greece. Miller, looking all too human, exposes himself to the camera; Durrell, on the other hand, impishly hides behind arms and a knee. The photo comes from Durrell's collection and most likely was contributed by Durrell with a chuckle at Miller's expense. Playful *joie de vivre* was certainly the glue that bound these two great friends together from 1935, when they met, to 1980, when Miller died. In the Prologue to this volume, Alfred Perles, an intimate friend to both men, highlights the "laughter and irrepressible gaiety" that issued from the Villa Seurat whenever Durrell came to call. That warm regard and good will prevailed through poverty, world war, nine marriages, physical disability, and, finally, worldwide recognition and success.

The *Letters* are clearly a testimony to a deep personal friendship, which went far beyond mutual literary concerns. Through the shifting fortunes of life and art, Miller and Durrell remained steadfast friends and supported one another with whatever resources were immediately at hand—whether money, publishing contacts, or simply encouraging words. The friendship began when Durrell wrote a wildly enthusiastic fan letter to Miller in 1935. Durrell praised *Tropic of Cancer* as a "howling triumph": "It strikes me as being the only really man-size piece of work which this century can really boast of." Though such

praise reads like blind idolatry and despite the fact that Durrell was a good twenty-one years younger than Miller, the relationship—at least in the pages of the *Letters*—is always on an equal footing. Miller describes the type of friendship the two shared: “[F]or the first time in my life someone bobs up who is more than a match for me” (46-47).

If there is any kind of climax in this volume, it occurs when Miller and Durrell, finally established as world-class writers, confront each other with negative criticism over later books. After reading *Sexus* in 1949, Durrell writes that he is “bitterly disappointed.”

But my dear Henry, the moral vulgarity of so much of it is *artistically* painful. These silly, meaningless scenes which have no *raison d'être*, no humour, just childish explosions of obscenity—what a pity, what a terrible pity for a major artist not to have critical sense enough to husband his forces, to keep his talent aimed at the target. What on earth possessed you to leave so much twaddle in? (232)

To such a frontal assault, Miller calmly replies: “I know you’d feel better if I did get angry with you, but I can’t. I laugh and shake my head bewilderedly, that’s all. . . . What I want to tell you is this—I said it before and I repeat it solemnly: I am writing exactly what I want to write and the way I want to do it” (233-34). In 1974, Miller turns the tables when he complains of his confusion after reading Durrell’s *Monsieur*, the first volume of *The Avignon Quintet*: “Brilliant, overwhelming, stupefying—yet, not quite what we expect. . . . (I can’t see more than a few hundred Americans capable of reading a book like this)” (475). Even though Miller and Durrell were the closest of personal friends, as far as their literary talents were concerned they were complementary opposites, as Ian S. MacNiven, the editor of the *Letters*, explains in another article entitled “A Critical Friendship: Lawrence Durrell and Henry Miller.” Miller describes his literary relationship with Durrell in terms of these opposites: “There are two types always—one working with & in Chaos, the other with law, form, etc. No use comparing them or putting one above another—systole & diastole: Apollonian & Dionysian, what!” (225). Miller, of course, considered himself a Dionysian artist.

Because Miller and Durrell were aware of their differences, strong criticism created hardly a ripple in their personal relationship. Perhaps that is because they shared a deeper bond—a Tibetan sensibility—which united them in their alienation from the materialist, goal-oriented West. Miller calls the U.S. the “land of doom” and Durrell often writes of the “English death.” To the two writers, Tibet and, sometimes,

China and Japan symbolize egoless existence, Zen, n-dimensionality, and Durrell's heraldic universe, "just a name for that element in which that queer fish the artist swims." Although Durrell was born on the Tibet-Indian border, neither man ever travelled to the land that had so captured their imaginations. Tibet seems to function as an escape hatch for the healthy development of the artist. For forty-five years, Miller and Durrell nurtured this imaginary land in the other. As Durrell acknowledges (in an unpublished letter that MacNiven quotes in his article), "Was ever a writer luckier in a true friend I wonder?"

The *Letters* comprise 210,000 words out of a million-word correspondence. An earlier edition of the letters, *Lawrence Durrell-Henry Miller: A Private Correspondence*, edited by Alan Thomas, appeared in 1963. But Thomas, who excised personal passages, had access to only half of the total correspondence, because Miller was to live seventeen more years. MacNiven, Durrell's authorized biographer, has done an admirable job in restoring the missing passages and adding new letters to the collection. As MacNiven notes, the *Letters* have "all the candour of an eavesdropped conversation between intimates." The conversation is so interesting that the reader regrets those rare gaps in the narrative when the writers were together and their discussions went unrecorded. Nevertheless, the *Letters* give us an excellent idea of the thought processes of two twentieth-century authors whose works are due for a reassessment and a revival.

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□ *Vertrauter Alltag, gemischte Gefühle: Gespräche mit Schriftstellern über Arbeit in der Literatur.* By Donna L. Hoffmeister. *Abhandlungen zur Kunst-, Musik- und Literaturwissenschaft* 382. Bonn: Bouvier Verlag, 1989. 178 pp. DM 48.00.

In this book of interviews, conducted between August 1984 and August 1985 with fourteen German fiction writers, Donna Hoffmeister sets out to present an inside view of the writing process and the "real person behind the literary mask" (1). Not surprisingly, such an endeavor is not always completely successful. After all, contemporary authors who understand their role as public figures might divulge some inside views to interested strangers, especially those in the literary field, but any sense of self (*áSelbstverständnis*) revealed in one interview is likely to be tainted by the subject's skill of self-representation (*Selbstdarstellung*). If authors have always been regarded as "Instanz[en] der Integrität" (2), this impression is derived from their written words, not